

Believe in yourself, not in superstitions

Discovering happiness **hinges on** passion and **diligence**, not **reliance on** external predictors. Be your own lucky charm through hard work

On Sundays, I usually find myself **glancing through** the weekly **forecasts** in the newspapers. A favourable week ahead is enough to bring a smile to my lips. It is good fun for the moment. But it was not always so.

A few **decades** ago, I was heading a major department in a Government production unit. Yet I was **restless**, not satisfied with the way my life was moving. Repeated **visits** to astrologers and their forecasts **became** the **opium** to **soothe** my **frayed nerves**. **So much so that** when I actually got another posting, I visited an astrologer for **reassurance** that the movement would be **auspicious**.

As I moved into an entirely different role, I found that I loved the new job with the same **zeal** that I had **displayed** in my earlier workspaces. I realised a few years later that **the key** to my happiness **was** within me—a passion to **immerse** myself in the moment. I have not gone back to an astrologer since then.

Years earlier, I was travelling with my colleagues one night to catch a flight to Europe for a study tour. The driver braked the vehicle to an **abrupt halt** as a cat crossed the road. The driver was **in a dilemma**. It was not a good sign. He resolved the issue by reversing the car a few metres before continuing to **ward off** the **ill effect**. I was to remember the incident when I had to **cut short** my stay by a couple of days having caught stomach flu, probably consuming beer and other **savouries** during the **Oktoberfest festivities** in Germany. **The feline** in Delhi **had** no **inkling** of its role in my **misfortune**.

I am often surprised at the measures taken by us, to **invoke** the blessings, or even to ward off the evil, for an unknown future. Many of us have gone through the process of our mothers feeding us curd and sugar when leaving home for the examinations. The **ritual** did not help me with papers that I had not prepared well. I also remember my elders telling me not to **call out** a person leaving home to avoid ill luck, even if I had something important to communicate.

This fear of the unknown **is** not limited to us only. Such superstitions **abound** even in the **so called** modern western world. We all have heard the **myths** of break a mirror and bad luck follows for 7 years, the curse of Friday the 13th, sneezes and blessings, fingers crossed, purse on the floor, money out of the door and **countless** others.

Cricket has been a craze in our country ever since I can remember. IPL is a relatively recent **phenomenon** that has **fueled** the **frenzy** to **unimaginable** heights. Fans **root for** players, who are not even **remotely** connected with the State or city after which the team is named. The tournament has also **sprouted** several home-grown **charms** to ensure victory. I am surprised to see people continuing to remain standing or sitting for the duration of the match, controlling the uncomfortable **urge** to

empty **bursting bladders**, or staying at home even at the cost of cancelling urgent engagements, among many other **quirky** behaviours.

A lucky charm would also work only if one acts, that too based on **sound reasoning** and an understanding of the risks involved. Even if one fails, it might not feel like the end of the world. Do it the other **way round** and it is a **heady cocktail** for disappointment.

American actress and comedian Lucille Ball's words inspire me to set myself free and be my own lucky charm: "Luck to me is something else: Hard work and realising what is opportunity and what isn't."

@mocks_wallah

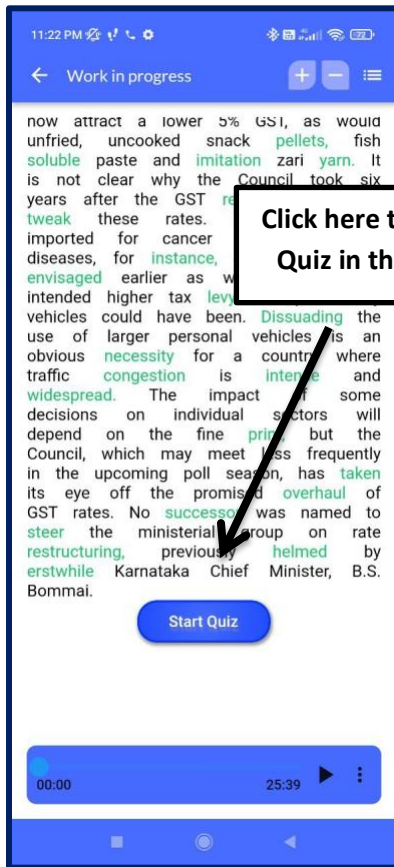
Vocabulary

1. **Superstition** (noun) – Belief in supernatural causality, myth, unfounded belief, irrational belief, fallacy अंधविश्वास
2. **Discover** (verb) – Find, uncover, detect, unearth, reveal खोजना
3. **Hinge** (on) (verb) – Depend on, rest on, be determined by, be contingent on, rely on निर्भर होना
4. **Passion** (noun) – Zeal, fervor, enthusiasm, ardor, dedication जुनून
5. **Diligence** (noun) – Hard work, perseverance, industriousness, conscientiousness, effort परिश्रम
6. **Reliance** (on) (noun) – Dependence, trust, confidence, faith, belief निर्भरता
7. **Glance through** (phrasal verb) – Skim, browse, scan, flip through, look over सरसरी निगाह डालना
8. **Forecast** (noun) – Prediction, projection, outlook, prognosis, estimation पूर्वानुमान
9. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
10. **Restless** (adjective) – Uneasy, unsettled, agitated, anxious, fidgety बेचैन
11. **Opium** (noun) – A narcotic drug obtained from the opium poppy, used to denote something that dulls the senses. अफीम
12. **Soothe** (verb) – Calm, pacify, comfort, alleviate, ease शांत करना
13. **Frayed** (adjective) – Worn, strained, tattered, frazzled, stressed तनावपूर्ण
14. **Nerves** (noun) – Anxiety, stress, worry, tension, apprehension तनाव
15. **So much so that** (phrase) – To such an extent that, to the point that, such that, to a degree that, so that इतना कि
16. **Reassurance** (noun) – Assurance, encouragement, comfort, confidence, solace आश्वासन
17. **Auspicious** (adjective) – Favorable, propitious, promising, fortunate, advantageous शुभ
18. **Zeal** (noun) – Enthusiasm, passion, ardor, fervor, eagerness उत्साह
19. **Display** (verb) – Show, exhibit, demonstrate, present, reveal प्रदर्शित करना
20. **Key** (noun) – Crucial element, essential factor, main point, core, foundation कुंजी
21. **Immerse** (adjective) – Engaged, absorbed, engrossed, involved, occupied मग्न
22. **Abrupt** (adjective) – Sudden, unexpected, sharp, quick, hasty अचानक
23. **Halt** (noun) – Stop, cessation, pause, interruption, standstill रुकावट

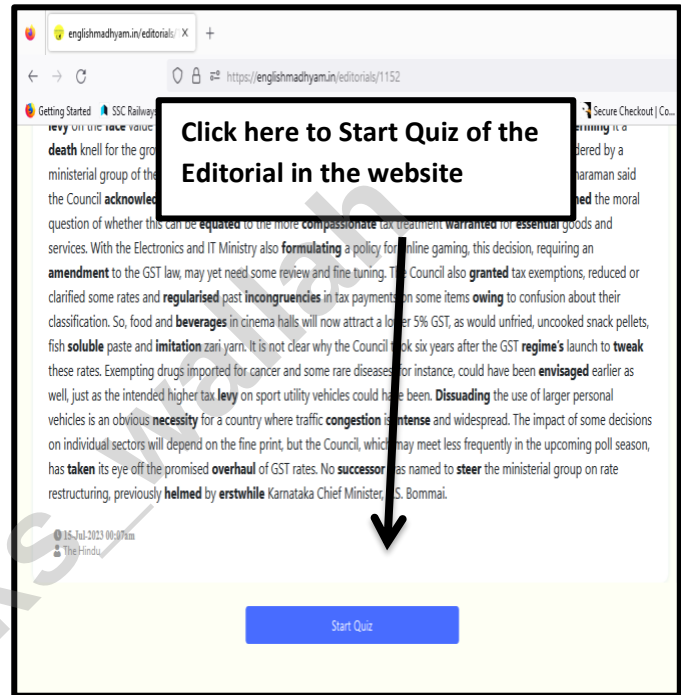
24. **In a dilemma** (phrase) – In a quandary, in a predicament, in a difficult situation, in a fix, uncertain उलझन में
25. **Ward off** (phrasal verb) – Prevent, repel, avert, avoid, fend off दूर करना
26. **Ill effect** (phrase) – Negative consequence, bad result, harmful impact, adverse outcome, detrimental effect बुरा प्रभाव
27. **Cut short** (phrase) – Shorten, abbreviate, truncate, reduce, curtail छोटा करना
28. **Savoury** (noun) – A dish that is salty or spicy rather than sweet. नमकीन
29. **Oktoberfest** (noun) – A traditional German festival held in Munich, characterized by beer drinking, music, and dancing. ऑक्टोबरफेस्ट
30. **Festivity** (noun) – Celebration, merrymaking, party, gala, fete उत्सव
31. **Feline** (noun) – Cat, kitty, tomcat, kitten, puss बिल्ली
32. **Inkling** (noun) – Hint, suggestion, notion, idea, clue आभास
33. **Misfortune** (noun) – Bad luck, adversity, mishap, setback, hardship दुर्भाग्य
34. **Invoke** (verb) – Call upon, appeal to, summon, solicit, request आह्वान करना
35. **Ritual** (noun) – Ceremony, tradition, practice, rite, custom अनुष्ठान
36. **Call out** (phrasal verb) – Shout, yell, summon, announce, name पुकारना
37. **Abound** (verb) – Flourish, be plentiful, be abundant, teem, proliferate प्रचुर होना
38. **So called** (adjective) – Alleged, supposed, purported, presumed, assumed तथाकथित
39. **Myth** (noun) – Legend, fable, misconception, folklore, tale मिथक
40. **Countless** (adjective) – Numerous, innumerable, myriad, infinite, many असंख्य
41. **Phenomenon** (noun) – Event, occurrence, happening, experience, situation घटना
42. **Fuel** (verb) – Stimulate, ignite, intensify, feed, encourage उत्तेजित करना
43. **Frenzy** (noun) – Hysteria, mania, madness, turmoil, agitation उन्माद/ पागलपन
44. **Unimaginable** (adjective) – Unthinkable, inconceivable, unbelievable, extraordinary, fantastic अकल्पनीय
45. **Root for** (phrasal verb) – Support, cheer for, back, endorse, encourage समर्थन करना
46. **Remotely** (adverb) – Indirectly, slightly, distantly, marginally, faintly बिल्कुल भी
47. **Sprout** (verb) – Emerge, grow, develop, arise, appear उत्पन्न करना

48. **Charms** (noun) – a special quality of a person or thing that makes the person or thing attractive आकर्षण
49. **Urge** (verb) – Desire, impulse, compulsion, drive, need प्रबल इच्छा होना
50. **Bursting bladder** (noun) – Urgent need to urinate due to a full bladder. भरे हुए मूत्राशय
51. **Quirky** (adjective) – Unusual, eccentric, peculiar, odd, whimsical विचित्र
52. **Sound** (adjective) – Solid, reliable, well-founded, logical, reasonable ठोस
53. **Reasoning** (noun) – Logic, rationale, argument, thought process, analysis तर्क
54. **Way round** (phrasal verb) – In the opposite manner, in reverse, conversely, contrariwise दूसरे तरीके से
55. **Heady** (adjective) – Intoxicating, exhilarating, thrilling, stimulating, exciting उत्साहपूर्ण
56. **Cocktail** (noun) – Mixture, blend, combination, concoction, medley मिश्रण

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